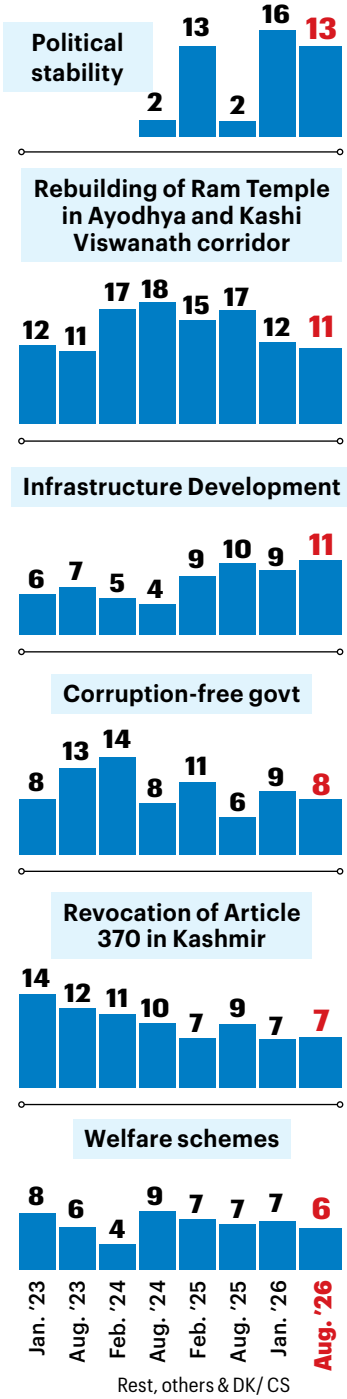


Q. What is the NDA govt's single biggest achievement?



contrasting its record with that of previous Congress governments has diminishing purchase. "When they are not bothered about Manmohan Singh, how can they be bothered about Nehru?" asks Deshmukh. For this generation, then, the question is no longer how much better the NDA is than the UPA was; it is far more immediate: what is the Modi government doing for them now?

Gen Z's concerns are personal: jobs, inflation, incomes and opportunity. Instead of Modi championing the distant dream of Viksit Bharat in 2047, as the prime minister did in his Independence Day address, young Indians and their parents want to know what his government will do for them in 2027—particularly on employment and incomes. The jobs problem is all the more telling because programmes such as Skill India and Digital India have raised expectations of upward mobility, only for many graduates to discover that well-paying employment remains elusive.

While voters appreciate the Modi government's infrastructure push, yesterday's luxury has become today's entitlement: highways and better infrastructure are increasingly taken for granted. For the young, the question is no longer how many roads have been built but, as Deshmukh says, "They think: Good. But what after that? I'm still not getting a job." They are unimpressed by jobless economic growth; they want growth that generates jobs.

While the BJP remains electorally resilient, a deeper generational and economic shift is under way that could steadily erode its advantage

THE COCKTAIL OF DISSENT

Why, then, has this cocktail of discontent not produced a more dramatic decline for the BJP? Two factors provide a cushion. First, much of the anger has yet to translate into personal hostility towards Modi, who retains a substantial leadership advantage and is still regarded by many voters as the best man for the job. Second, dissatisfaction with the BJP has not translated into a corresponding surge for Rahul Gandhi or the Congress. Those looking for an alternative do not yet see Rahul as the solution provider. Instead, younger voters appear increasingly willing to explore third alternatives—from Vijay to Prashant Kishor and other credible state- or constituency-level challengers.

For the BJP, therefore, the danger is less an immediate electoral rout than a gradual erosion of the assumptions on which its dominance has rested. Modi's popularity remains the party's greatest asset, but its heavy reliance on him also means that any decline in his personal authority could prove disproportionately damaging. Nor can the problem be solved simply by shifting political communication to Instagram. "The problem," says Deshmukh, "is not in the medium but in the messaging." Gen Z is also less willing to be cowed by the aggressive political language that may have worked more effectively with earlier generations. Labelling those who disagree with the ruling establishment as anti-national could increasingly prove counterproductive.

The immediate test for the ruling dispensation will be the upcoming assembly elections in states where it is currently in power, especially UP, where accumulated discontent could find expression at the ballot box. The larger message from this MOTN is that while the BJP and NDA remain electorally resilient, a deeper generational and economic shift is under way that could steadily erode their advantage unless they reorient both their politics and their messaging. There is a warning for the Opposition, too: opposing the government for opposition's sake will not suffice; it must offer more credible solutions to the livelihood concerns that are fast becoming the new measure of political performance. What Gen Z has done is shake up the old rules of political bargaining. How parties adapt will determine whether they win or lose. ■